Reengineer your JOB DESCRIPTIONS?

Traditional Job Descriptions won't necessarily get you the results you want.

Dr M Amr Sadik



One of the main elements of an effective Human Resources Department, particularly the Recruitment or Hiring Unit, is to come up with effective, concise, precise and workable Job Descriptions for the current and potential staff, thus each staff member can understand what is expected from him/her to deliver.

In my first role as a Human Resources Director with a multinational organization, they send me, from head-office, a 5 - 7 page job description that I took to my General Manager and told him, "This is the joke of the year. Do you think I'm going to even read it?"

I have seen and gone through quantities of job descriptions. Some of them are perfectly well written, while others are scrawls and doodles on paper.

HR people spend hours trying to perfect the JDs with fancy phrases to impress either the boss or the reader, but with no adding value or even mentioning what to deliver as outcomes. In addition, I always provoke and argue with people about who is responsible for this product that we call it JDs.

Are we medical doctors, engineers, marketers, salespersons, pharmacists, etc, who can write any job descriptions? Of course, the answer is, "No, we are not all of that," so the question is: "Who are we?"

We are just engineering the process and the custodian of this paper. We develop the



right template, conducting a job analysis, interviewing people and coming up with a draft that ought to be reviewed by the specialised people or the direct bosses for revision and approvals, and then we do the last fine-tuning.

HR Practitioners are falling into this trap. They believe that, by copying other JDs from here and there, they became the master, and they stick to this misperception and sometimes become irritated if someone objects, and no wonder, then, that although 72% of recruitment managers say they provide clear descriptions, only 36% of candidates agree.

We need to come up with a Job Effectiveness Description that is worth writing and worth reading.

In my personal opinion, the current JDs must contain two new elements that are imperative to the job itself and the jobholder.

The first element is Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) that allow people to judge on performance and the outcomes of that particular job, and must be quantitative.

The second element is Critical Success Factors (CSFs), the limited number of areas in which results, if they are satisfactory, will ensure successful performance, and/or areas of activity that should receive constant and careful attention from the employee.

We do not want people to fail in their jobs, we want to recognize and celebrate their achievements and superior performance that ultimately will affect the organization's bottom-line.

The critical success factors will depend on the objective or the job role's key result areas (KRAs). Remember, key result areas are thrusts or major focuses in this case for improving the job. To improve performance, the best method is to determine the CSFs.

Furthermore, after discussing this context approach with one of my dearest colleagues, Dina Marie, she recommended adding personality types, particularly for the recruitment of a new candidate. I was totally convinced.

Finally, Job Descriptions are more than just a document; they are an integral element of an effective HR structure. They summarise what a role's purpose is, what it is accountable for achieving and how those achievements are to be measured. The tasks and duties of the job description are how a role achieves its purpose.

It is, therefore, time to reengineer your traditional Job Descriptions for better results that can impact on job postings. ■

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